

OPAUDIT 020 - The security fix that disconnected the skins

Audit ID	2026-10-05-020
Report date	2026-10-05
First observed	Repeated live presentation and routing regressions after the September 28 skin execution-boundary migration; consolidated as one incident on October 5 after GAME ON, TILEZ, AURORA, JIVE TURKEY, and imported SMACKTALK content exposed missing replacement contracts.
Theme	The security decision was right. The migration was not complete. Executable behavior was removed from skins without first inventorying, rebuilding, and proving every bounded CMS-to-skin contract that had supplied the visible site.
Surfaces	Schema-v2 public skins; strict public controllers; route compatibility; saved appearance settings; shared assets and components; SMACKPRESS imported content; crawler-file lifecycle; skin packaging; CMS and skin release sequencing.
State	OPEN CMS 0.7.819D and GAME ON 0.1.24 are deployed and their bounded recovery is live-verified. CMS 0.7.820D repairs a newly proven fleet-wide crawler-file lifecycle defect and passes local tests; packaging, deployment, and fleet verification remain required. Whole-fleet parity is not claimed.
Human impact	Approximately two weeks of recovery work less than one month before closed beta, damaged trust and morale, lost sleep, and severe autism-related distress reported by the owner, including feeling physically sick. Repeated model-capacity failures prolonged the recovery despite available account quota.
Reporter	Sean identified and repeatedly reproduced the live failures. Codex reconstructed the repository evidence and wrote this report. Model attribution for earlier individual changes remains unproven unless a session record establishes it.
Related	SECAUDIT 059 (skin execution boundary), SECAUDIT 060 (migration-integrity follow-up), pre-migration reference v0.7.772D, controller migration beginning at c9eb3a9e .
Publication	Owner-gated. The report is intentionally candid; publish only after the recovery is deployed, independently reviewed where required, and the evidence table is completed.

1. SUMMARY

SnapSmack correctly decided that skins must not own database access, request routing, writes, remote calls, or reusable application behavior. The implementation treated that boundary as a removal exercise instead of a contract migration. Old skin code was stripped out and generic replacement layouts were installed before every route, setting, component, asset hook, and interaction had a central replacement and a parity test. Security gates proved that authority was gone. They did not prove that the site still worked.

The predictable result was a long sequence of releases that each restored another missing connection: backgrounds, opacity, navigation, search, complete feeds, image links, static pages, Blogrolls, footers, post

counts, saved hero images, clean routes, and skin-specific presentation. The owner was repeatedly told that a repair was done, then found the next regression on the live site. This was an operational failure, not a collection of unrelated cosmetic defects.

2. WHAT FAILED

Failure	Evidence	Consequence
No complete pre-migration contract inventory	Pre-migration GAME ON, AURORA, PARADE, and JIVE TURKEY each had roughly twelve presentation templates/partial. The replacement process produced one generic <code>layout.php</code> per skin. The read-only parity diagnostic later found 646 candidate CSS hooks that existed before migration, remained referenced, and were no longer emitted.	Necessary presentation behavior vanished even though the new security boundary itself passed.
Tests proved containment, not parity	Migration/parity suites passed while live skins lacked backgrounds, controls, routes, images, Blogroll styling, footers, and viewer behavior. A route audit found 45 declared-route fallthroughs across 12 skins.	Green gates were incorrectly treated as evidence that the visible product survived the migration.
Generic replacements crossed independent skin contracts	Repository history contains mechanical grid, public, and SMACKTALK restoration scripts and generic replacement commits <code>6cab3a9c</code> , <code>2fe6d73d</code> , and <code>a28749e5</code> .	Distinct skins were changed as a batch without route-by-route and setting-by-setting acceptance evidence.
Release completion was declared too early	From 0.7.773D through 0.7.816D, dozens of development tags and many commits named <i>Restore</i> followed the migration. New omissions were repeatedly found only after packaging or live deployment.	The fleet became the parity test environment, multiplying recovery work and owner stress.
Version order was not respected	TILEZ 0.2.59 was packaged and installed while 0.2.58 had not been deployed, despite the owner repeatedly requiring strict sequence. The owner also reported having to finish and deploy CMS 0.7.817D after the assistant stalled, then deploy 0.7.818D.	The version ledger stopped being a trustworthy statement of what had been seen, installed, and verified.
Communication increased rather than reduced load	The owner repeatedly had to distinguish CMS defects from post data, skin defects from shared assets, and source changes from deployed behavior. Repeated capacity errors interrupted the same recovery thread.	The person already doing acceptance testing also had to supervise scope, sequence, and basic state reconstruction.

CMS-owned crawler files were not part of install/update completion	A 25-site read-only audit found <code>/sitemap.xml</code> returning 404 on every site although <code>/sitemap.php</code> worked; 10 sites lacked <code>llms.txt</code>, the other 15 identified old CMS versions, and 6 lacked <code>robots.txt</code>. The generator ran only after manual settings/maintenance actions, while the canonical router omitted the advertised sitemap alias and fleet updates never reconciled the files.	Sites could report stale or absent AI/search guidance indefinitely after successful CMS updates. The failure was centralized but presented as fleet drift, adding another unplanned recovery immediately after the owner asked whether the CMS maintained these files.
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3. REPRESENTATIVE REGRESSIONS

- SMACKPRESS-imported images lost their larger-image/lightbox association, and a repair initially targeted the wrong layer instead of the imported post contract.
- TILEZ images widened outside their original footprint on hover; its configured standard footer was present but hidden by a shared drawer controller that claimed the same generic identifier.
- GAME ON lost animated framed-image state, direct photograph routing, background content on secondary pages, styled Blogroll and About presentation, saved About imagery, ordinary footer flow, and the distinction that its landing page already is its archive.
- AURORA's engine remained registered but its intended visibility and post-viewer relationship were not adequately acceptance-tested. JIVE TURKEY's suspected scrim regression was investigated and not confirmed; the saved value was zero.
- Legacy public links and configured menu records continued to use `?view=` and PHP filenames rather than clean owner-facing paths such as `/diary` and `/blogroll`.
- The CMS advertised `/sitemap.xml` in generated robots files without ever installing that route, and failed to regenerate `robots.txt` and `llms.txt` during ordinary or fleet updates.

4. ROOT CAUSE

The project optimized for the absence of forbidden code and failed to specify the presence of required behavior. A skin-security migration has two acceptance conditions: the old authority must be gone, and every legitimate result that authority used to produce must arrive through a bounded central contract. Only the first condition had a strong gate.

The work was released in fragments before a representative fleet matrix was complete. A source test, a DOM token, or one repaired site was repeatedly allowed to stand in for live route and interaction parity. That made each release another discovery step instead of a controlled rollout.

The release process did not honor the owner's sequential constraint. This was not harmless bookkeeping. Strict order is both a technical traceability requirement and an accessibility requirement for this owner. Repeating the violation after it had been explicitly explained materially worsened the incident.

5. CORRECTIVE ACTIONS

1. For every skin family, maintain a pre-migration ledger of routes, settings, emitted structure, shared assets, interactions, and saved-value behavior. Each item must be classified as restored, intentionally retired with owner approval, or still open.
2. Test both halves of every security migration: forbidden authority is absent; required output and behavior are present. A security ratchet alone is never a parity gate.
3. Require browser acceptance for landing, detail/modal, static page, Blogroll, archive semantics, navigation, footer, responsive behavior, and the skin's defining interaction before publishing a skin recovery.
4. Keep releases sequential: create N, package N, deploy N, verify N, then and only then create N+1. A skipped build requires the owner's explicit recorded cancellation; an agent cannot infer it.
5. Separate diagnosis, source repair, package publication, installation, and live verification in every status report. Never use “fixed” when only source tests have passed.
6. Do not bulk-rewrite forkable skins. Shared behavior belongs in audited CMS assets and bounded view models; each skin's presentation remains independently reviewed.
7. Record the human cost and accessibility consequences in incident closeout, not only the code delta and test count.

6. CURRENT RECOVERY EVIDENCE

Item	State	Evidence
CMS 0.7.819D	Deployed and bounded verification complete	The hub and 24 connected sites report 0.7.819D. Clean routes, GAME ON pages, standard footer flow, and the targeted imported-post repair were live-verified.
CMS 0.7.820D	Locally tested	Exactly 0.7.820D; canonical sitemap route and shared install/update crawler-file reconciliation; 164 PHP regression programs pass, 0 fail; no skin files changed.
GAME ON 0.1.24	Deployed and bounded verification complete	Presentation-only template; landing, direct photograph modal, Blogroll, About page, saved hero/background state, animated frame state, and standard footer flow live-verified.
TILEZ	Unchanged	Remains 0.2.59. The clean-route and idempotent import-repair work is CMS/tool-owned.
Security boundary	Gate passes	A draft template-side validation change was rejected by the fleet ratchet before release; validation was moved to core and the ratchet then passed.
Crawler repair deployment	Open	0.7.820D has not yet been packaged or pushed. The 25-site failure counts are pre-repair evidence and must be rerun after fleet deployment.
Whole-fleet parity	Open	Neither this candidate nor this report represents all remaining skin findings as closed.

7. CLOSURE GATE

This audit closes only after CMS 0.7.820D is packaged and deployed in order; all 25 audited sites answer the public sitemap route and carry current CMS-generated crawler files; the formal security follow-up is independently reviewed; the remaining fleet parity ledger has an owner-approved disposition; and no later version is created to hide an incomplete earlier one.

8. ADDITIONAL CRAWLER-FILE ADMISSION

We said SnapSmack sites maintained their own SEO and agent-facing files before checking the fleet. They did not. The generator existed, but we had not connected it to install or update completion, and the route it advertised did not exist. This should have been a release invariant from the first version that emitted `Sitemap: .../sitemap.xml`. The owner found the missing control by asking a basic product-responsibility question during an already exhausting recovery.

9. PLAIN ADMISSION

We made a necessary security change in an unsafe operational way. We removed code from skins before proving that the CMS supplied everything those skins legitimately needed. We relied on tests that could pass while sites were visibly broken. We released too many partial repairs, broke version order after being told not to, and left the owner to find and supervise regressions that should have been caught before deployment. The resulting loss of time, trust, and wellbeing was avoidable.